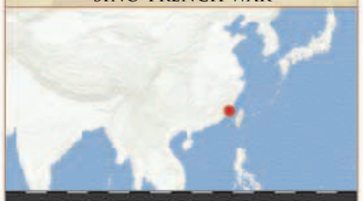
SINO-FRENCH WAR



THE BATTLE OF FOOCHOW

Date	August 23, 1884
Location	Fuzhou, southern China
Result	French victory

COMBATANTS

FRANCE	CHINA

COMMANDERS

Amédée Courbet	Zhang Peilun

FORCES

Ships: 8 ships, 2 torpedo boats	**Ships:** 11

LOSSES

Men: 5 killed **Ships:** none	**Men:** 521 killed **Ships:** 9 sunk

THE BATTLE OF FOOCHOW

In search of an Asian empire, France was extending its influence over Vietnam, traditionally regarded by the Chinese as under their suzerainty. In 1883 the French took control of Tonkin, the area of Vietnam closest to the Chinese border, after a French naval squadron commanded by Rear Admiral Amédée Courbet blockaded the Vietnamese capital, Hue. Although France and China officially remained at peace, Chinese troops were sent to fight the French in Vietnam.

In August 1884 Courbet, promoted to vice admiral, took his squadron of warships north to the Chinese port of Foochow (Fuzhou). Lying on the Min River, this was the base of the Fukien Fleet, one of China's four regional navies. After a series of humiliating defeats by European forces, the Chinese government had embarked on a policy of "self-strengthening," which aimed to modernize its army and navy with the help of European experts. The condition of the Fukien Fleet revealed how limited the progress had been. Most of its few steamships had unarmored wooden hulls. Its only large-caliber guns were carried by its two Rendel gunboats, "flatiron" coastal defense vessels which provided a platform for one 10in gun apiece. Antiquated sailing junks still made up a large part of the fleet.

IMPERIAL POWER

Because France and China were at peace, the French were permitted to anchor their warships in the Min River among the ships of the Chinese fleet and various other European vessels. Courbet kept two of his three armored cruisers (the most powerful ships in his squadron) at the mouth of the Min River, where they played no part in the subsequent battle. One armored cruiser, *Triomphante*, and three unprotected cruisers—*D'Estaing*, *Villars*, and *Dugay-Trouin*—anchored opposite the gunboat *Chen Wei* and two Chinese wooden warships. The smaller French ships moored further up river, where the rest of the Chinese fleet, including the flagship *Yang Wu* and the flatiron gunboats, were clustered.

At 1:56 p.m. on August 23 the French opened fire without warning. Together *Triomphante* and the three unprotected cruisers mounted over 40 guns, most of larger caliber than the Chinese guns. They made short work of *Chen Wei* and the two wooden ships. On the face of it, the French ships up

> "HE WAS VERY CAREFUL NOT TO SHED FRENCH BLOOD. HIS BATTLES WERE HIGHLY ORGANIZED, WORKED OUT IN ADVANCE ... WITH SO RARE A PRECISION"
>
> **PIERRE LOTI**, FRENCH SAILOR AND WRITER, DESCRIBING ADMIRAL COURBET

